on social freedoms and democratic setbacks. Taksim's challenge eroded the government's ability to project its model of conservative Islam and undermined its pretence at regional supremacy over its rivals Iran, Egypt and Saudi Arabia. Turkey ended up being drawn into the revolt it had hoped to defuse.

Regression in the periphery

The global crisis negatively impacted the classical periphery. It hit hardest economies that export basic goods, import processed products, and suffer the plundering of their natural resources. These countries cannot rely on the shock absorbers that intermediate economies can call on to temper the impact of an unfavourable international context. They remain ravaged by the adverse political conditions imposed by neoliberalism that eliminated any countermeasures which previously limited global polarisation. The collapse of the socialist bloc and the loss of historic gains by workers in the First World have only facilitated the opening of this breach.

The periphery is made up of economies which have suffered the greatest impoverishment. At the extreme end of the poles, abysmal income differences persist. The per capita GDP of the Congo (US$231) or Burundi (US$271) places them light years from Monaco (US$114 232) or the United States (US$48 112). These fractures have grown significantly during the last decades so that the gap which separates per capita income in the richest and the poorest regions has risen between 1973 and 1998 from 13.1 times to 19.1 times. There are many statistics which demonstrate the geometric expansion of the chasm which separates the first 40 countries in the global rankings from the last 40 countries.[24]

The accumulation of capital on the global scale always involves an international division of labour which leads to the transfer of resources from the periphery to the centre. In its neoliberal stage, this polarising dynamic continuously modifies how this process takes root in various localities. The expansion of growth in certain areas is consummated at the expense of others through unequal exchanges and processes which recreate underdevelopment.[25] Polarisation can be verified in a dramatic form by looking at the worsening of hunger. This social tragedy has been on the rise since 2003, powered by a cycle of rising foodstuff prices. Until 2008, shortages were mostly concentrated in grains and certain cooking oils. But it then extended to affect all products. In December 2010, the Food and Agriculture Organisation price index surpassed its all-time high. Hopes for decreasing prices based on a global slow-down have not been realised. Hunger affects around 1.2 billion people, but its threat extends to 2.5 billion people living in poverty. We need only recall that food shortages influenced the opening stages